

Mothering and making it, in and out of prison

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Mothering from the inside: Parenting in a women's prison, Sandra Enos. New York: State University of New York Press, 2001. 176 pp. (including index). \$16.95. ISBN 0-7914-4850-9.

Making it in the free world, Patricia O'Brien. New York: State University of New York Press, 2001. 201 pp. (including index). \$19.95. ISBN 0-7914-4862-2.

Each of these books explores new terrain among a growing body of literature on the expanding population of incarcerated women. With an estimated 145,000 women in prisons and jails, three out of four of whom are mothers of multiple children, there are more than 175,000 children now living apart from their mothers with whom many were residing before their incarceration (Johnston, 1995). The typical incarcerated woman is a single parent responsible for the care of her children. Most of these women have been incarcerated before. At the current rate, at least two out of three will recidivate and approximately half of their children will also fall into the criminal justice system. Enos helps us understand the consequences of their roles as mothers, while O'Brien provides valuable insights into what it takes for women to reintegrate into their communities and make it in the free world.

Enos's *Mothering from the inside* makes a significant contribution as the first full-length book to detail and deconstruct experiences faced by mothers in prison. She reports a nearly 75 percent increase in the numbers of incarcerated women since she began her research in 1992, largely a consequence of harsher sentencing policies. Enos provides a thorough, textured analysis of how women in prison understand and practice motherhood. Her research is based on interviews with 31 women in a correctional facility and several months in the role of participant as observer in a parenting program as researcher and program volunteer.

Mothering on the inside, like mothering on the outside, is affected by social class, access to resources, family support and cultural factors. Enos cites holes in related research with regard to understanding the influences of race, ethnicity and class and emphasizes how race and ethnicity differentially affect incarcerated mothers' pathways to crime and their caretaking options for their children.

White women linked their involvement in drugs and crime to poor parenting they

received, which often left them estranged from family, Enos reports. Consequently they lacked the option (and desire) of placing their children with a parent and their children were more often either with a husband or in foster care. African American women more often claimed their own mothers 'did the best they could . . . but that the temptations of the street were too much for them to resist' (p. 59). Similarly, Hispanic women typically connected their incarceration to the 'lure of quick money through drug sales' (p. 57), and both African American and Hispanic women more often relied on family members to take care of their children.

Enos suggests that a family's willingness to extend help is related to families' 'expectations of trouble' (p. 51), noting that for some families, incarceration might be 'routine' (p. 51). However, she does not explain why white incarcerated mothers cite poor parenting more than non-whites, or why they are more likely runaways and consequently have fewer family member caregivers but more husband caregivers. Enos explores the differences between being a mother, doing mothering and negotiating the position of mother while in prison. She explains how incarcerated mothers negotiate their identities as a mother, their participation in mothering, and their attachments with their children. Mothers might minimize the pains of imprisonment and separation from their children by giving up control of managing their children and their caretakers. Some women tried to put their concerns and emotions aside by calling less often or not putting up their children's photos.

Mothers in prison attempted to be good mothers by making sure their children were well taken care of by others. At the same time, they maintained that mothers care for children in a way that only a mother can. Some claimed the irreplaceability of biological connections and reported that much of the emotion work that only mothers can do was left undone during their incarceration.

Enos found some mothers struggled to keep their identities as 'good mothers' separate from their drug-user identities. Others recognized they either think they are being good mothers but they are not, or that eventually they compromise their mothering ('You can be an addict and a mother for a while. You can go along for just so long and then eventually something will go out of control' p. 120). The possibility of being active mothers to their children was incentive for getting and staying clean and a critical part of demonstrating fitness to mother. These women also proved fitness through arranging visits with their children, attending parenting classes, demonstrating knowledge of their children's school activities, friends, teachers and problems and by developing plans for reunification after release.

Enos ends with recommendations sensitive to the impact race and ethnicity have on incarcerated mothers' experiences. She wisely suggests supporting family caretakers during a mother's incarceration and after her release to help prevent future displacement of children. Although Enos does not cover consequences for children, such support will help prevent future problems among their children, which typically go untreated and often lead them into cycles of incarceration.

Like many books on this population, Enos rightly recommends expanding alternative sentencing programs where women can remain in the community with their children. Most incarcerated women are serving time for non-violent, victimless crimes. If such recommendations were ever followed, alternative sentencing programs could reduce recidivism rates by disrupting fewer families already living at the margins and

reducing the pain and trauma children often suffer when separated from their mothers. Enos also suggests correctional staff be trained to recognize 'promising' and 'problem' mothers to identify those more likely to reunify with their children and provide appropriate interventions. It is difficult to make such distinctions accurately, particularly within the institutional environment, and labeling prisoners 'problem' mothers will likely only create more problems for them and their children. However, interventions that consider whether a mother will resume her role as primary caregiver or have her parental rights terminated is sensible and would help prepare women for their transition after incarceration.

Enos astutely notes variations by race and ethnicity but pays less attention to their common denominator of poverty. The majority lack a high school degree, have not worked outside the home, have received public assistance and now have a criminal record. These credentials have a profound influence on their opportunities and odds of success upon release. Their status as incarcerated mothers cannot be separated from their socio-biographical contexts.

Nevertheless, Enos has indeed covered a considerable amount of complex territory. This thorough, well-organized book will be of value to social scientists and other criminal justice professionals. However, the author's academic style makes it less compelling for voters or legislators. The emotional pain these women often report gets lost in the operationalization of their experiences, leaving this population of mothers as 'others'. Future research and writing on these issues should consider the style in which we want to write in order to influence people in positions of power to pay attention to some of these most marginalized families in our society.

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O'Brien offers a refreshing, optimistic perspective on a population of women who are beating the odds and 'making it in the free world' after serving a prison sentence. Most research on prisoners develops recommendations based on what is wrong with either prisoners or the prison system. O'Brien on the other hand, carefully analyzes the achievements of 18 women who have been out of prison between six months and 12 years and are successfully (re)building their lives in the free world. She provides a holistic, intelligent and compassionate examination of formerly incarcerated women offering significant lessons about what it takes to make it in the free world.

O'Brien uses a sophisticated and sensitive empowerment framework that outlines the circumstances related to women's successful transition from prison. She explores the social contexts that often lead to women's crime: 'Empowerment theory posits individual problems as arising not from personal deficits, but from the failure of society to meet the needs of all people' (p. 27). O'Brien outlines the contextual etiology of their involvement in crime and shows that women are most commonly incarcerated for drug and property offenses. Empowerment theory recognizes the social forces that influence addiction and emphasizes the need to understand the weight addiction imposes on a woman's transition. O'Brien identifies key factors that contribute to success: addressing concrete needs, establishing healthy relationships and revitalizing the self. She includes women's narratives that give an up-close look at their daily challenges. Successful reintegration requires a job that supports herself and often her children, and a safe and

affordable place to live. A legal income is a springboard for everything else a woman needs to do to (re)build her life after prison. These women found support from family, ex-inmates and the community critical during their transition. O'Brien points out the centrality of relationships in the lives of these women and their struggles to repair and maintain them. She recognizes the importance of women's willingness to seek assistance through their relationships. The women in this study recommend lining up such sources of support before leaving prison.

Developing relationships that inspire their confidence and well-being helped them overcome the stigma of ex-inmate and contributed to their internal processes of change. Their relationships with their children were also a significant source of self-efficacy and an integral part of successful transitions, however, O'Brien found that reunification was not a necessary condition for 'making it in the free world'.

As O'Brien concedes, these 18 cases are not representative of the general population of incarcerated women. Given that at least two out of three incarcerated women released will recidivate and these 18 women are 'making it' renders them atypical. These extraordinary women had more education, more work experience outside the home, more savings and were more often married than most incarcerated women. Moreover, one-third of this sample spent the final months of their sentence in a community facility where they had individualized help preparing for interviews and finding jobs. Even though several women resented the house staff intruding in their lives, this halfway house environment offered time to reintegrate without the full responsibilities of supporting themselves and their children. These six women were able to move into their own residences more directly compared with those who did not have the community placement option. It is precisely the characteristics that make this sample unrepresentative that illustrate what it takes to successfully re-establish themselves within their communities. These women are examples of transformations that are possible – given adequate resources and support. The only missing details are the specific ways in which these remarkable women overcame their addictions and mostly avoided relapse.

O'Brien offers sensible ideas for working within existing policies and also suggests graduated decarceration of non-violent offenders. She recommends individualized plans for incarcerated women that identify resources both in the institution and the community where she will return that help develop skills needed for living wage employment. O'Brien endorses community-based, women-only halfway houses with staff who can facilitate job placement. She advocates that professionals facilitate contact with children in and after prison so that a mother can more gradually regain her parenting role in a process that supports both mother and child. O'Brien reiterates the importance of drug treatment inside prisons, and even more importantly after release.

Finally, O'Brien suggests that a feminist vision of justice would create community-based, alternative sentencing programs for non-violent offenders that take into consideration the contexts in which crimes are committed and place the responsibility for healing on both the individual and society. While such a vision requires a significant shift in public discourse on crime and punishment, O'Brien leads us in the right direction: 'This will require a social acceptance of responsibility for the conditions of injustice that brought these women into conflict with the law' (p. 141).

Reference

Johnston, D. (1995) 'The effects of parental incarceration', in K. Gabel and D. Johnston (eds) *Children of incarcerated parents*, pp. 59–88. New York: Lexington Books.

SUSAN GREENE received her PhD in social psychology from the University of California, Santa Cruz. She has conducted a number of research projects in psychology and law on topics concerning social history and crime, the treatment of incarcerated mothers and their children and a range of social-policy-related issues focusing on women in jail and what they experience after release. Susan is the founder of Getting Out and Staying Out, a program that helps incarcerated women prepare for release and provides aftercare during their transition back into the free world.
